

SUPPORTERS OF JAGAN DEMANDING HIS INSTALLATION AS THE CHIEF MINISTER

asking party workers to leave the state leadership issue to the high command, and third, seeking votes in the Tekkali assembly byelection—are indicative of his ability to handle issues from a larger perspective. Reiterating what YSR had said a couple of days before his death, Jagan appealed to people to strengthen the party under the leadership of Sonia Gandhi and said the Congress would retain power in the 2014 polls and Rahul Gandhi would become the prime minister.

Though his primary focus has been diversifying the family interests in mining to establish and run mini-hydel power stations in Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, Jagan has recently shown political acumen by raising resources through some seemingly questionable means to launch a multi-edition Telugu daily *Sakshi* and a TV channel by the same name. Its tremendous impact, apart from negating what the pro-TDP dailies portray, has also helped in playing the role of a symbolic unifying factor for Congress activists. He also helped some new generation aspirants get party tickets and win in the recent elections.

Evidently all this is a fallout of YSR developing 'Team Congress' under his leadership in a manner no other party leader has done. This is also why no other claims to chief-ministership are being made though there are a few aspirants. Instead of coming out in the open, considering the clout and support for Jagan, they are waiting in the wings hoping to be chosen by Sonia. The names doing the rounds include Union ministers S. Jaipal Reddy, M.M. Pallam Raju and D. Purandeswari as well as Rajya Sabha member K. Keshava Rao. Apprehensions about possible squabbles has made the party agree readily to the experienced veteran K. Rosaiah taking charge to ensure smooth, uninterrupted functioning of the Government particularly



THE CONGRESS IS BANKING ON VETERANS TO HOLD THE FORT **BUT THE PUBLIC DEMAND FOR JAGAN TO TAKE OVER WILL BE TOUGH TO IGNORE.**

when large parts of the state are parched because of untimely if not deficient rainfall.

The immediate challenge for the Congress is to ensure that the numerous programmes initiated by YSR are propelled by the same momentum in a cash-strapped state in order to consolidate the votebanks. None is better equipped for this than YSR's friend and confidant, KVP Ramachandra Rao, widely called KVP and a Rajya Sabha member, who understands nuances, is adept at micro-management with personal knowledge of constituencies and has direct contact with local leaders.

The Congress is banking on his services but the AICC is undecided on whether it will be possible for the party to deliver with Jagan at the helm nudged by KVP. A nagging question is whether all sections of the party will be with him or is it safer to persist with a senior like Rosaiah who can engage and accommodate diverse groups with remarkable ease. Equally vital is the long-term challenge about the usefulness of having a young, resourceful leader steering the party into the 2014 elections. YSR is a tough act to follow but for a son ready to step into his father's shoes, perhaps less so. ■